

LANDING IN DEEP PIT

Allies at the Centre, tussle between the Congress and the two Left parties over land reforms takes an ugly turn

■ By Amarnath K. Menon

Hell hath no fury like friends turning into enemies. For proof, look no further than Andhra Pradesh where the comrades-in-arms running the UPA Government in Delhi, are standing daggers drawn. The Congress and the two Communist parties—CPI and CPI(M)—who have tangoed even through some difficult times for over three years now, are finding it hard to look each other in the eye.

The Communists have been a worried lot ever since the impetuous and tough-talking Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy decided to keep the pre-poll promise of distributing land and building houses for the poor. Apprehensive that Reddy will rob them of their agenda, given the seriousness with which he began implementing land reforms, both the Left parties have stepped up the pressure on the Government by forcibly occupying public and private property to demand quicker implementation of land reforms.

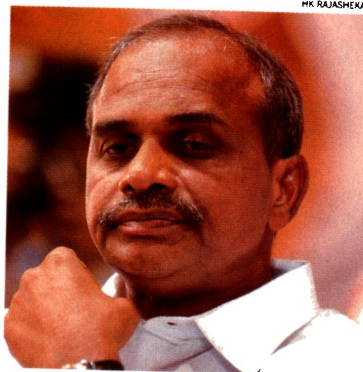
Last week, the inbroglio took an ugly turn when policemen, armed with automatic rifles, including AK-47s, fired indiscriminately at a group of Marxist workers who were sitting on a day-long bandh in protest against the delay in land reforms. Seven people were killed in the firing, which took place on the Khamman-Kodad road in Mudigonda in Khammam district. The policemen, it was alleged, were not even in their uniform.

The incident has come as a serious setback for the Congress as early evidence suggests that the police firing was unjust and only one of the seven

killed was a Communist worker. The trigger-happy policemen, usually deployed for anti-Maoist operations, overlook the normal practice in dispersing a mob and are quick to draw their firearms. After a brutal lathicharge this time, they opened fire. The chief minister, who has, at review meetings of senior police officers in the past one year, repeatedly emphasised that the police, while handling demonstrations, should refrain from opening fire on protesters under all circumstances, said he was saddened at the developments but made it clear he would not step down. There were calls for his resignation immediately after the incident. Being the fourth such mishap since he took over, Reddy clearly is on the defensive.

When his repeated appeals to the two parties to call off their *Bhu Poratam* (land struggle) launched on May 2 this year failed, Reddy set up a three-member group of ministers to discuss the Government's efforts to implement land reforms including the recommendations of a committee headed by the

PH. RAJASEKHAR



Municipal Administration Minister Koneru Ranga Rao that he himself had appointed to go into all the issues relating to this.

However, the Communists stuck to their course. Their agitation acquired violent hues, with the party cadres instigating the poor to forcibly occupy government and private land by hoisting red flags and pitching bamboos to put up huts. The police used force to evict them but they continued with their ways and slowly emerged as a political challenge to the ruling Congress when they began using women and children as human shields. Despite provocations, the police exercised restraint and tackled the mobs through lathicharge and ar-

"It's the most regretful incident of my life. An agitation should be done responsibly."

Y.S. RAJASEKHARA REDDY, ANDHRA PRADESH CHIEF MINISTER